



Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 4 – Business Management (June 2022 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

The multiple-choice questions tested the candidates' fundamental knowledge of business management in various aspects, including marketing, strategic management, international business, finance, and control. In addition, there were several questions that required candidates to apply a deeper understanding of the concepts and knowledge to different aspects of business management.

Generally, candidates performed quite well on straightforward questions and those that required conceptual understanding, but performance on scenario questions was noticeably worse since these questions required more application of the concepts.

Specific Comments

- Marketing research
- Service management
- Organizational behaviour
- Compensation of human resource management
- Quality management
- Finance

(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

The questions in this section aimed to examine candidates' conceptual understanding of different topics in business management and their ability to apply the knowledge to specific scenarios related to the companies. Candidates were required to respond to the questions by applying relevant concepts and knowledge as mentioned or indicated in the scenarios given in the questions.

Generally, candidates were good at answering simple questions which tested simple concepts (for example, PESTEL analysis), but when asked to demonstrate more conceptual understanding or to provide definitions of a particular concept, they did not perform very well. Moreover, candidates appear to have mixed up similar concepts.



For the questions that required more reading and extensive application of concepts, candidates did not perform very well. This shows that the candidates may not have prepared well and may have not covered all the topics in the study pack.

Specific Comments

Question 1(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define person-job fit. Almost half of the candidates were able to answer this question and, thus, received full marks. About half of the candidates were able to score half of the marks of this question.

The concept itself is self-explanatory and thus, even though the candidates missed this part during the preparation, they were still able to provide a relevant answer.

Question 1(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain the selection methods described in the scenarios. While this seems to be an easy question, only some of the candidates managed to score half of the marks or above. No one received full marks for this question.

Question 2(a) – 1 Marks

This question required candidates to identify the entry mode adopted by the company to enter the foreign country. The majority of the candidates could not answer this question as many of them were confused by different modes of entry (for example, exporting, licensing and franchising).

Question 2(b) – 9 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the issues mentioned in the scenario for international trading. Performance on this question was satisfactory, with many of the candidates receiving more than half of the total marks. The scenario provided sufficient information regarding the issues, and the candidates were required to state these clearly and accurately.

Question 3(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to illustrate the product position map based on the information provided in the scenario. This question appears to have been difficult, as candidates were required to understand the product position map clearly and were required to apply this to the case information. Thus, almost no candidates received full marks, with a majority of candidates receiving only half of the marks.



Question 3(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the promotion activities suggested for the company. This question was quite easy and, thus, candidates performed well, as many of the candidates may have had experience with promotion activities.

Question 4(a) – 1 Marks

This question required candidates to define crisis management. More than half of the candidates were able to get full marks for this question. A few of them did not include the key point that the crisis would negatively affect the organization. Again, this question was not that difficult, and even candidates that may not have prepared well were able to receive partial marks if they wrote something relevant to the term.

Question 4(b) – 9 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the crisis management process with the illustration and examples of the company mentioned in the case. Only a few candidates managed to receive a good mark, though no candidates received full marks. Some candidates were able to recall the crisis management process, but they did not explain the concepts well as many of them jumped directly to the application and illustration. This prevented them from receiving full marks.

Question 5(a) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the elements of service concepts which could also be adopted by the case company. Although most of the candidates were able to explain correctly, a few confused the term with service characteristics. Again, this shows that many candidates did not have a clear understanding of similar concepts under the same topic.

Question 5(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to describe the techniques used to measure and interpret the financial risks faced by the case company. Performance on this question was poor, and almost all of the candidate received no marks. It is because this topic is seldom tested in past examinations and candidates did not prepared well for this topic.

Question 5(c) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to list and summarise the factors that the case company should take into consideration. Performance on this question varied, with very few of the candidates receiving full marks and quite a number of the candidates receiving zero marks. Most candidates received only partial marks. Similar to the previous question, it is because this topic is seldom tested in past examinations and candidates did not prepared well for this topic.



Question 6(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain the primary activities (value chain analysis) based on the information provided in the scenario. More than half of the candidates received at least half of the full marks or more. Thus, performance was quite good for this question.

Question 6(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state and illustrate the elements of PESTLE for the company in the scenario. Performance on this question was relatively quite good as this concept is very simple and candidates should have learnt and covered the topic in their Business Management textbook. However, some candidates did not relate the relevant PESTLE factors to the case information. This shows that their application skills were quite weak.

Question 6(c) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define a just-in-time system. This term should be well-known to the candidates, and thus, even though they did not prepare for this topic, they could still write something and receive partial marks. However, only a few were able to receive full marks. Many candidates simply provided the answer based on their understanding without sufficient preparation of the concept.

Question 6(d) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the advantages and disadvantages of adopting a just-in-time system for the company. Few candidates scored full marks, as most of the candidates appear to have not read the question carefully and provided incorrect answers.



(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

Overall, the performance of the candidates was satisfactory and better than the previous cohort. Although many of the problems experienced here were similar to those encountered by previous candidates, many of the candidates this time were able to write relevant answers for the questions. This may have been due to familiarity with the topics and common sense. Candidates may have encountered the concepts regularly or they were able to guess the meaning of the concepts, thus, instead of scoring zero marks for the questions, most of them would still gain some points. However, since this module covers a wide range of topics which requires candidates to prepare well and study the topics and concepts carefully, the results still show that candidates were not able to tackle questions which covered some difficult concepts, such as service concept, product position map, techniques to measure and interpret financial risks, and factors for consideration when making financial decisions. Based on these weaknesses, some advice is provided below so that candidates can prepare well for the examination.

First of all, candidates should read questions carefully. Some questions were simple and straightforward; however, candidates might not have read the questions carefully and thus provided incorrect or irrelevant answers.

Secondly, it is advised that the candidates should not skip topics. As mentioned before, this module has a wide coverage of topics and concepts, ranging from basic management concepts to financial management and control systems. Therefore, candidates should start preparing for the examination earlier in order to have sufficient time to study, particularly for those topics that they are not familiar with. It is understandable that many of the candidates may be engaged in financial and accounting professions, and thus these topics would be relatively easier to them. This means, however, that candidates should read and prepare more thoroughly for topics which they may not be familiar with, such as control systems, service concepts, or marketing.

Finally, most of the questions require candidates to explain and describe the concepts before application to the case information. Candidates were sometimes able to apply the relevant concepts, but they did not explain and describe the concepts well. This led to these candidates not receiving full marks. Thus, candidates are advised to explain and describe the concepts first. Of course, the exact order and composition of candidate responses always depends on the wording of the questions. Therefore, candidates are also advised to read the questions carefully. If they are asked to identify or state, then they may not need to provide elaborate explanations of the concepts; but when they are asked to explain and describe, they should prepare some explanation of the concepts in their answers.